



“spoil of war” or through the slave trade. Many slave women (and men) worked as domestic servants in wealthy households.

One unlikely group of women did have some freedom and access to education. Women known as *hetairai* (courtesans) served as companions for wealthy men in Athens. These women were often educated and able to live independently. They were hired for their company and friendship, and often attended aristocratic banquets known as *symposia*. A few women began as entertainers before becoming *hetairai*, and were therefore also skilled musicians and dancers.



and insult each other in what was called the *aischrologia*. On the third day, they rejoiced.

Prophetic priestesses

The Greek women who became priestesses had authority and independence outside of marriage. The most famous of these was the priestess who delivered oracles on behalf of the god Apollo in Delphi,

◀ Symbol of aristocracy

Mirrors, usually small enough to hold in the hand, were a status symbol in ancient Greece because only elite women could afford to buy them. This fifth-century example is made of bronze.



BIOGRAPHY SAPPHO

A lyric poet from the Greek island of Lesbos, Sappho wrote sensual hymns of poetry which were primarily concerned with deep love and yearning. The word “lesbian,” meaning a woman of Lesbos (and used to refer to women of her school of thought), is derived from her birthplace. Her verses were unique for the time in that they spoke from one person to another. She composed nine volumes of works, but the only text to survive in its entirety is her *Hymn to Aphrodite*. Sappho is believed to have died around 570 BCE.

Religious participation

Greek women played an active part in religious life and some festivals were celebrated only by women. The festival of Thesmophoria, held annually, was dedicated to the goddess Demeter and her daughter Persephone, and observed only by married women. Demeter was the goddess of the harvest and fertility and so this three-day celebration took place to promote agricultural fertility. It also referred to an episode from Greek mythology, commemorating Demeter’s grief at the marriage of Persephone to Hades, god of the underworld. Under no circumstances were men allowed to participate in the festival, and preparations to exclude them began nine days before it started.

The women adhered to strict customs that included completely abstaining from sex. On the first day of the festival, women came to the gathering place (the Pnyx in Athens) and the second day was spent fasting and mourning, in imitation of Demeter’s anguish at Persephone’s abduction. During the second day, women would curse at

